which had the word ‘Royapuram’ painted over the once-etched ‘Rayapuram’, the station’s old name.

The markings and the type of rails that form the support of a station’s roof and its pillars, base and brackets overhead usually give an important lead on the station’s and the line’s genesis. For example, the year and the name of the foundry or the railway company the rails originally belonged to give us insight into the history of the station and the line in general.

But the rail markings here on this platform simply said ‘XII/1956 ←’ and the rails were modern and flat-footed, unlike the ones used in the earlier days of the Indian Railways. [1] So these were newer, with little link to the station’s origins.

I still had to look around. The tall Gothic and fluted columns, now painted over, the foyer, the arched doorways and entrances, the wood-beamed high roof and decorative metal brackets were the only significant relics visible at Royapuram station. The station’s building, rather what remained of the old building—renovated a decade ago, circa 2005—was a shadow of its former self. It appeared majestic even in its current form. It seemed as if it was looking down upon the electric trains passing by. After all, it belonged to a different age—the glorious era that had gone by, when railways were the future and trains the fastest mode of communication.

Historically and officially, the 1853 Bombay-Thana railway line (now Mumbai-Thane) was the oldest passenger railway line in the country, but none of the stations on this route exist in their original form. Royapuram does, though I don’t know how long it will continue to do so, with the Southern Railway now planning an expansion of the station. This essentially means an upgrade—more lines, more trains and more passenger amenities.

This is why I had come here—just to be at the station and spend a few hours trying to connect with it. And I must say, it still is in a class of its own, standing out among all the stations in Chennai.

IN SEARCH OF MARKERS

A few kilometres away, after switching local trains or EMUs (electric multiple units), I reached Chennai Egmore—another landmark. Egmore is the anglicized form of ‘Ezhumbur’, the name of a pre-British-era village situated on the northern banks of the Coovum river. The station is the